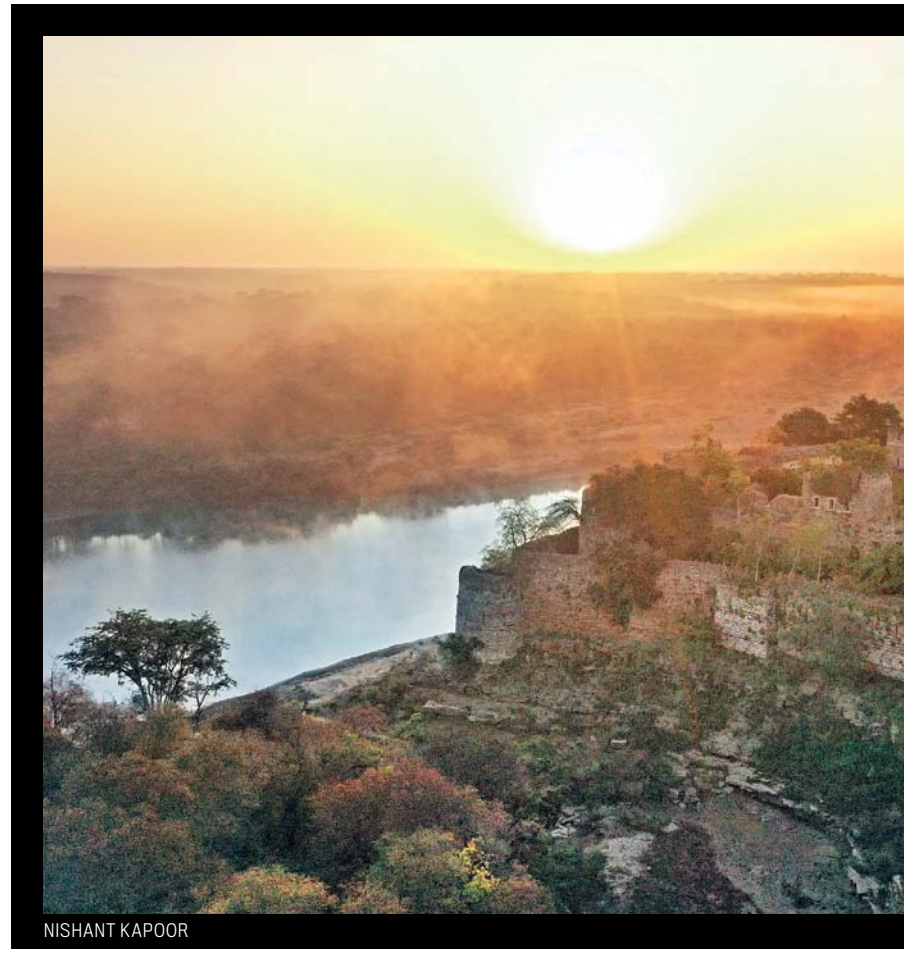

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famous tiger reserve, Ranthambore. The reappearance of the cheetah in India—via the translocation of eight individuals from Namibia—is by itself a remarkable fact. For, while the name 'cheetah' is itself of Hindustani origin—deriving from the Sanskrit *chitraka* or 'painted'—the last time the cheetah hunted in these parts was 75 years ago. Rather, *they* were the hunted. In 1947, the last three of India's native cheetahs were sighted—in an aspect of defeat (see *And Then There Were None...*). Photographed with their long, sleek bodies lying slumped and lifeless at the feet of the gun-toting Maharaja Ramanuj Pratap Singh Deo of Koriya, in present-day Chhattisgarh. In 1952, the cheetah became the first animal to be declared extinct in independent India—even if it likely survived as a few scattered, forlorn coalitions into the '60s. That's the situation sought to be reversed now, with what will be the world's first intercontinental translocation of a big carnivore in the wild, unless you count the Gwalior maharaja's attempt to source lion cubs from Africa in 1920 only so as to hunt them in the forests of Gwalior. On September 17, a month after India marked 75 years of freedom, a handful of cheetahs will tiptoe into a controlled forest enclosure to breathe the free air of a country that hosted them for millennia and gave them their name—and also tortured them to extinction. A project at once ambitious and modest, carefully designed yet risk-prone, the cheetah steps will be monitored with avid interest by wildlife experts not just in India but also around the world.

A SPOTTED HISTORY

For, this 'small big cat' from the puma lineage, *Acinonyx jubatus*, had likely been as endemic to India as its cousin felids from the panthera family—the tigers and leopards. In fact, recent genetic studies, including on the remains of a 19th century cheetah from MP, propose a split with the African variety much deeper on the species time-scale—about 72,000 years ago—than thought before. For millennia, therefore, the cheetah had roamed our lands in the hundreds of thousands. Just like they had in other continents. From southern Africa, where the earliest fossils of *A. jubatus*, dating from about 3.9 mya, have been found. To ancient Egypt and Sumer, where evidence for tamed cheetahs crop up in visual and scriptural lore. To continental Europe, where they are depicted on the Chauvet cave paintings from circa 30,000 BC. In Europe and the Americas, they did not survive the mass megafaunal extinction at the end of the Pleistocene, a kind of big mammal holocaust that occurred as the curtains fell on the last Ice Age, and also wiped out the sabre-toothed tiger and the woolly mammoths. The cheetah survived in Africa, West Asia/ Egypt, and India. Even if the human hand, to which is ascribed a large part of the blame for that mass extinction event, did not pause its actions.

CHEETAHS ROAMED INDIA'S GRASSLANDS IN VAST NUMBERS FOR MILLENNIA TILL THE HUMAN HAND PUSHED THEM TO EXTINCTION

Cheetah hunting was itself a thing—and unrelenting. But the historical epoch also came to be replete with cheetah coursing—hunting game with tamed cheetahs playing the same role as hounds. The cheetah had a special trait of vulnerability here: it is largely non-aggressive towards humans, and could be tamed after about a year, but unlike the hounds, couldn't breed in captivity. All the cheetahs that filled the royal courts and annals of diplomacy—becoming symbols of prestige from the Holy Roman Empire to the Mughal court—were caught wild. From the pharaohs to Genghis Khan (who liked to ride with one on his saddle) to the 16th century Pope Leo X, who liked exotic animals as gifts, all partook of this. As did count-